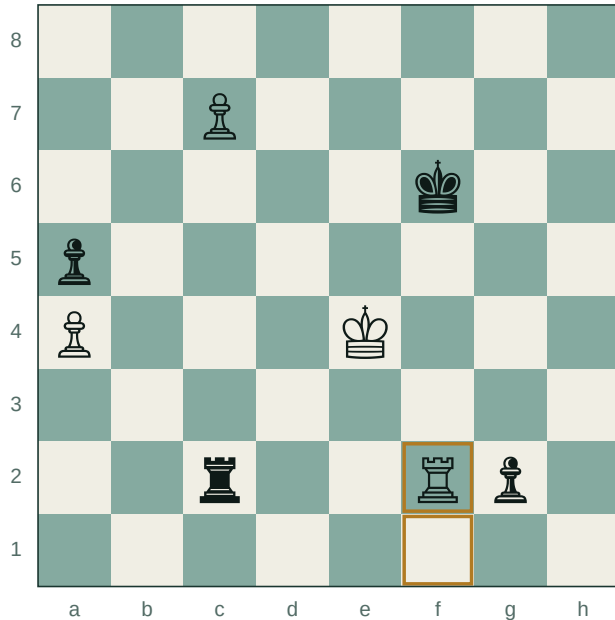


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 38

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 38.Rxf2+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

38...Rxf2 39. c8=Q g1=Q 40. Qf8+ Ke6

38...Rxf2 The rook captures the rook on f2. Recorded reply: **39.c8=Q**.

39...g1=Q The pawn moves from g2 to g1. The pawn becomes a queen. Recorded reply: **40.Qf8+**.

40...Ke6 The king moves from f6 to e6. The changed line means the rook on f2 attacks the queen on f8.

At the end, nominal material is White 10 / Black 15 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from +0 to +5. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on e4. Geometrically undefended: rook on f2. Check for tactical protection.